

The job market for new college grads keeps getting worse

Early-career hiring has plummeted from pre-pandemic levels, with this year's graduates seeing fewer openings and fewer job offers.



— Less than half of college seniors reported being offered a job before graduation in a recent survey.

Anisha Chopra / Getty Images

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By Ashley Mowreader

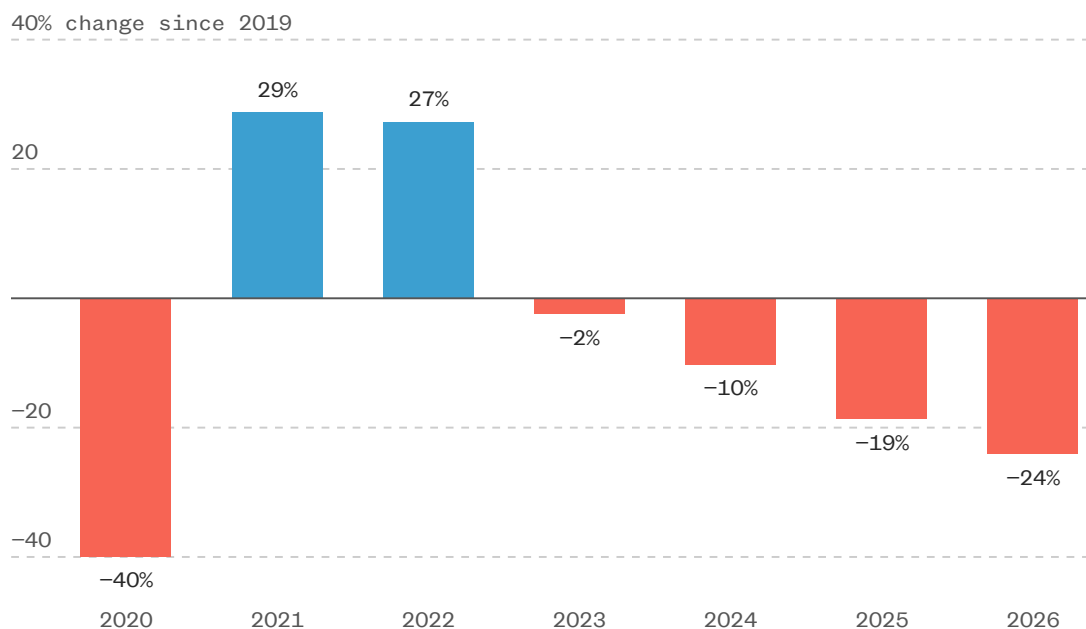
For new grads, the excitement of getting their college degrees may not outweigh the anxieties of entering a precarious job market.

Data from job boards and surveys show an unusually cool job market for new graduates, as well as a multiyear decline in entry-level job postings. For new graduates, experts say this results in discouraged job-seekers, more competition and higher rates of unemployment.

Entry-level hiring rates have sunk five years in a row and are now more than 20 percentage points lower than in 2019, according to recent data from LinkedIn.

Entry-level hiring falls further below pre-pandemic levels

The hiring rate for entry-level talent dropped 24% between June 2019 and June 2026.



Notes: Hiring rate is measured by the share of LinkedIn members who update their profiles with a new employer.

Source: LinkedIn

Graphic: Ashley Mowreader / NBC News

The trendline for entry-level hiring looks similar to that of the U.S. job market since 2019; in 2020, there were [fewer open roles and higher rates of unemployment](#) as companies shrank budgets to weather the impacts of Covid restrictions. As stay-at-home measures eased, the economy saw [a surge of jobs](#), creating opportunities for talent of all levels and [sparking the “great resignation,”](#) in which people were more likely to leave their jobs for better opportunities.

But in the years since, [the job market steadied in 2024](#) and [then plummeted last year](#), with [little growth so far this year](#).

“It wasn’t just the case for college grads or new grads; everyone was experiencing that slowdown” in recent years, said Kory Kantenga, LinkedIn’s head of economics for the Americas. “The concern is, will it pick up?”

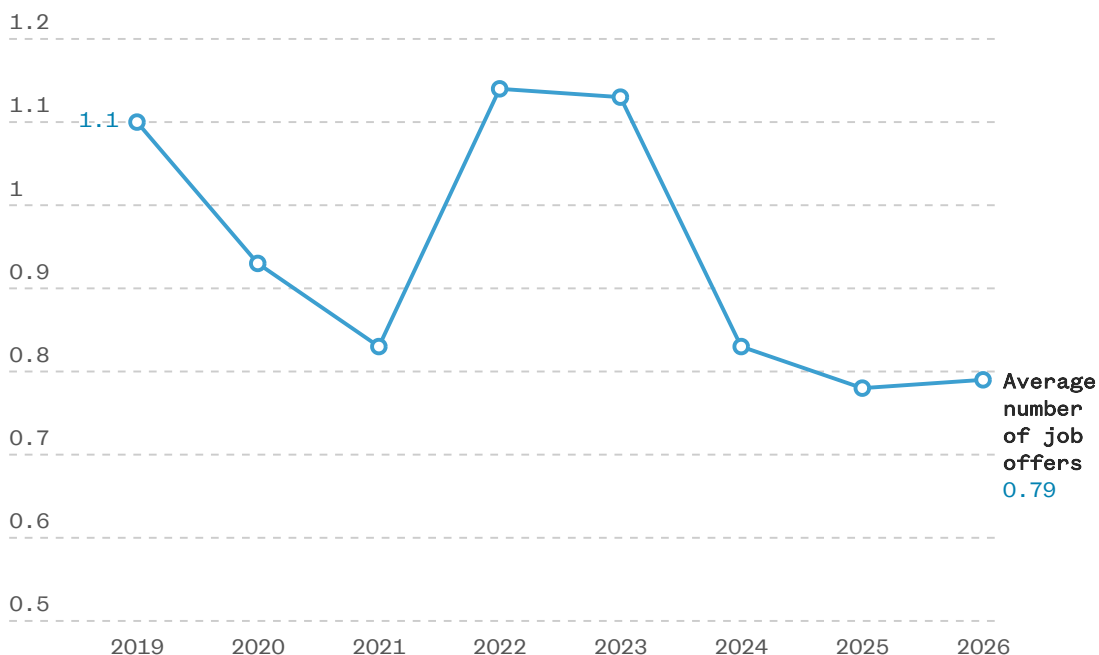
This [low-hire, low-fire](#) job market has made entry-level roles more competitive and made it more common to find workers some describe as “[job huggers](#).”

These “huggers” are hanging on to their current jobs even if they’re dissatisfied with the role, said Randy Tarnowski, director of research and an economist at Handshake, a job board geared toward college students. “There’s a legitimate challenge for students entering in.”

One way this challenge bears out is in the application stage. Compared to their peers who graduated in 2019, the class of 2026 is applying for more jobs but receiving fewer job offers, according to survey data from the National Association of Colleges and Employers, known as NACE.

Not enough job offers to go around

The average graduating senior this year received 0.79 job offers, which means many finish school without an offer.



Notes: NACE's survey was conducted from March to May and includes responses from 1,860 graduating seniors.

Source: [National Association of Colleges and Employers 2026 Student Survey](#)

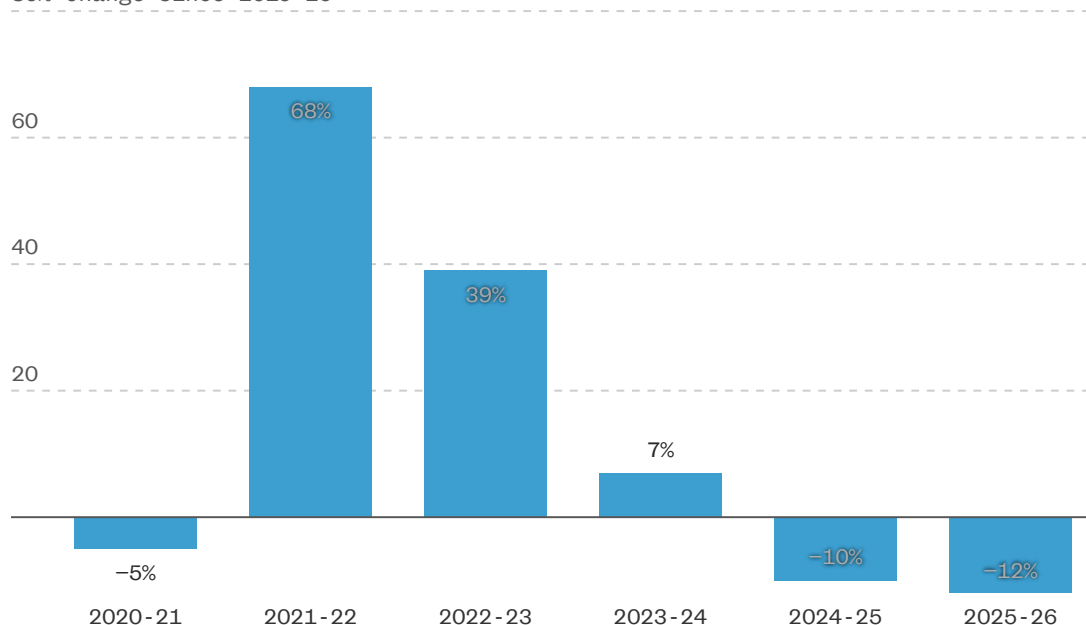
Graphic: Ashley Mowreader / NBC News

Job postings geared toward current students and recent graduates on Handshake have also dropped since 2019, after peaking during the 2022 academic year.

Jobs for graduates decline

Full-time job postings for graduating college seniors have been declining in recent years, compared to 2019-20 levels.

80% change since 2019-20



Notes: Data compares an index of full-time jobs posted on Handshake from July to March of a given academic year, indexed to the class of 2020 (July 2019 to March 2020).

Source: Handshake

Graphic: Ashley Mowreader / NBC News

Macroeconomic trends such as [higher interest rates](#), trade policy, immigration issues, high energy prices and other economic uncertainties have given some employers pause on hiring for all talent, but especially entry-level roles, said Shawn VanDerziel, president and CEO of NACE. Some companies have [reduced headcounts](#) and [offloaded tasks to AI technology](#) to cut costs, targeting lower- or entry-level positions first.

Fewer job openings overall create more competition for existing jobs – including the entry-level opportunities for new college graduates, he said. “Not only are they competing amongst their peers, but they are also competing with more experienced candidates.”

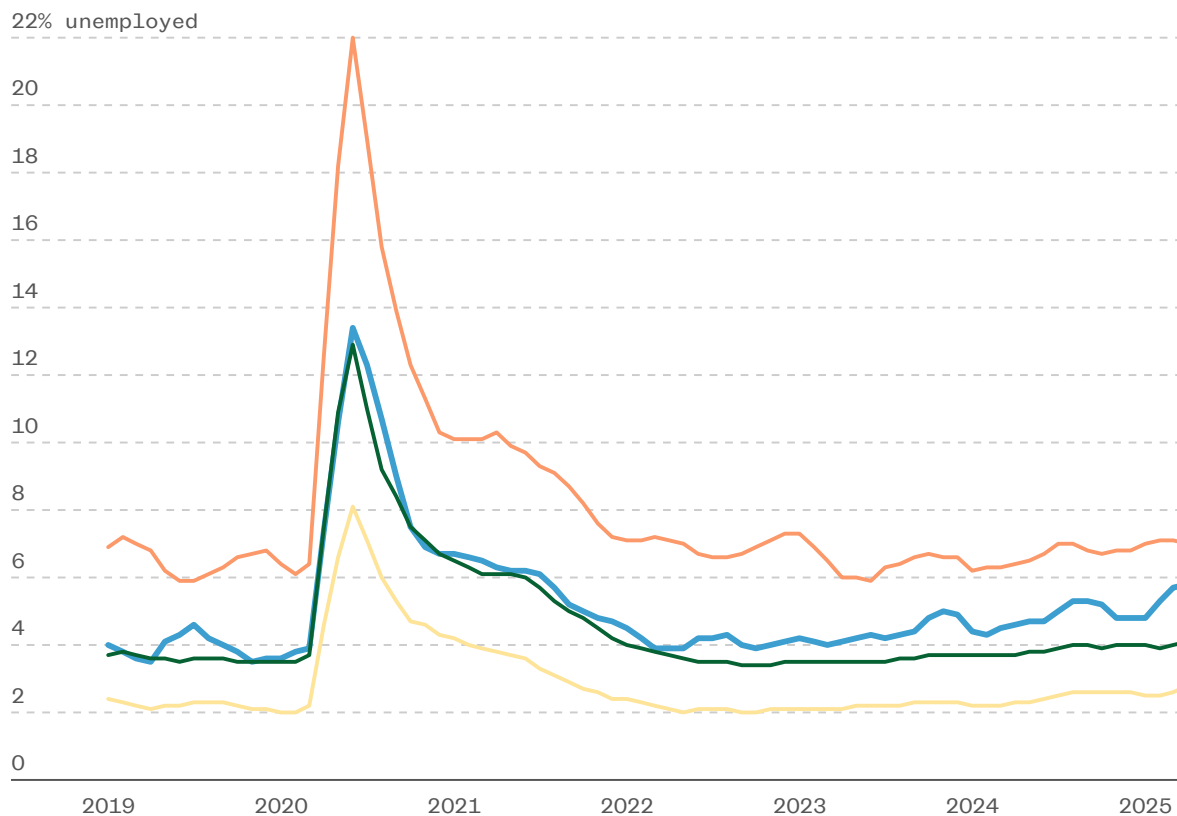
[An Indeed analysis](#) found workers with more than five years of experience send the most applications to entry-level jobs and even those who have spent more than 10

years working apply for entry-level roles.

The result is a mostly stagnant unemployment rate, with young workers and recent graduates both with higher-than-average unemployment. Unemployment for young college graduates is 5.6% as of March, according to the latest data.

Recent college grads faring worse

Unemployment rates among young college graduates remain elevated since 2020 while the general population has seen some recovery.



Notes: Young workers and recent graduates are ages 22 to 27.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau and U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Current Population Survey (IPUMS) via [the Federal Reserve Bank of New York](#)

Graphic: Ashley Mowreader / NBC News

Current college students see the job market as bleak. In [a July 2025 survey of the class of 2026](#) by Handshake, more than half of rising seniors said the current news about the job market makes them feel pessimistic about their career. More than half attributed their lack of hope to high competition for jobs, job security concerns and a lack of available jobs.

LinkedIn's average on-platform job applications per job doubled in 2025 compared to 2019, but have since slowed this year, which Kantenga connects to overall labor market frustrations.

In Handshake surveys, students talk less about their dream job and more about a stable job, Tarnowski said, one example of the ways cost of living and an uncertain job market creep into students' post-graduation plans.

But the pendulum may be swinging back in the 20-somethings' favor. Employers, [as surveyed by NACE this spring](#), expect to hire more entry-level talent this year. Larger employers or those in information and engineering industries were the most likely to increase hiring.

And for the firms that want to continue to innovate and adapt, particularly in using artificial intelligence, bringing in new talent is paramount, Tarnowski said. "It would be at the peril of some organizations to not bring in new talent."

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